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INSIGHT

U.S. Military Operations Against Iran: Munitions and Missile Defense

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Since the United States and Israel launched military operations against Iran on February 28, 2026, some Members of Congress have raised concerns about and sought information from the Department of Defense on the stockpiles and availability of munitions (e.g., ammunition, bombs, missiles, torpedoes, anti-aircraft weapons, and missile interceptors). (DOD is "using a secondary Department of War designation," under Executive Order 14347 dated September 5, 2025.) Following the Trump Administration's request for FY2026 supplemental funding, including $67.1 billion for military operations against Iran and other DOD activities, the House adopted a concurrent resolution (H.Con.Res. 113) that would allow for accelerated consideration of reconciliation legislation to provide $60 billion in mandatory defense funding beginning FY2027, potentially to include funding for munitions.

In September 2026, President Donald Trump said, "we have more munitions than we could ever possibly even think of using," and DOD officials have said sufficient munitions are available. The DOD Office of Inspector General, citing the DOD Office of the Under Secretary for Acquisition and Sustainment, stated that "the munitions expenditure in [Operation Epic Fury] has resulted in strategic inventory shortfalls and revealed industrial base bottlenecks for munitions resupply" and that the "defense industrial base requires 'significant lead time' to expand production capacities."

U.S. Capabilities Expended in Operations Against Iran

DOD has not made public the precise numbers of specific types of munitions expended in the conflict. The House and Senate Committees on Armed Services have reportedly received classified briefings with Administration officials on the conduct of operations. In congressional testimony on May 14, Admiral Brad Cooper, commander of U.S. Central Command (CENTCOM), stated that the U.S. military conducted more than "13,500 strikes" in the initial 38 days of "major combat operations." The United States and regional partners "intercepted over 6,000 one-way attack drones and more than 1,500 ballistic missiles," according to Admiral Cooper.

An April 2026 assessment by a U.S. think tank estimated that the United States had expended substantial quantities of selected, high-cost munitions in the conflict, including Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) and Patriot interceptors, Joint Air-to-Surface Standoff Missiles, and Tomahawk missiles. An

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August 2026 news article, citing U.S. officials, reported the U.S. military had expended approximately 1,700 Patriot, 200 THAAD, and 150 Standard Missile interceptors. In September 2026, the Congressional Budget Office (CBO), comparing public reporting on U.S. missile defense interceptor munition purchases with reported conflict usage, estimated that the United States had "probably used between one-half and two-thirds" of its inventory of certain missile interceptors.

Cost of Expended Munitions

On June 24, 2026, the Office of Management and Budget submitted to Congress a supplemental funding request for defense and other Administration priorities that included a $21 billion request for "munitions." Subsequently, DOD presented varying estimates of the cost of replacing munitions expended since February 2026. For example, DOD has also estimated the cost of replacing expended munitions at $27.7 billion, according to CBO. In September, CBO, citing reporting from publicly available sources on the quantities of munitions expended, estimated the cost to replace munitions expended through August 1, 2026, was $21.7 billion, including "$7.3 billion for the land-attack cruise missiles, $13.1 billion for the missile defense interceptors, and $1.2 billion for other munitions." CBO estimated that it "would probably take at least five years" to replace certain interceptors even at an increased rate of production.

Congressional Action on FY2026 Supplemental Request

On July 22, the House adopted a concurrent budget resolution (H.Con.Res. 113) that included reconciliation instructions to the House Armed Services Committee to "submit changes in laws within its jurisdiction that increase the deficit" by no more than $60 billion for the period FY2027-FY2036. The resolution did not specify the amount to be allocated to munitions. In a statement, Representative Jodey Arrington, chair of the House Budget Committee, stated that the resolution would provide the "bombs, bullets, and battlefield readiness … to finish the fight." On July 23, the resolution was received in the Senate. As of this product's publication date, the Senate has not considered the measure.

Potential Considerations for Congress

Appropriations for Munitions. In FY2025 and FY2026, Congress took steps to increase munitions stockpiles and production by authorizing and appropriating funds, among other actions. Congress may consider whether or not to provide additional funds for munitions used in the Middle East. Congress may also consider whether or not to increase funding for munitions in FY2027 appropriations and subsequent years.

Munitions Inventories. Congress is considering legislation that would require reporting on the financial cost of operations against Iran (H.R. 8800, §1089E), as well as on the status of U.S. munitions stockpiles and inventory requirements (H.R. 8800, §321; S. 4784, §872). Congress may also consider conducting oversight of related issues, such as the amount of time required to replenish munitions stocks, as well as options for low-cost alternatives to existing missile interceptors and weapons for countering drone threats.

Missile Defense Integration and Foreign Military Sales (FMS). The United States has sought to integrate missile defense efforts with allies and partners in part through sales of U.S. equipment. Finite U.S. industrial base capacity introduces trade-offs between filling FMS orders and replenishing U.S. stockpiles. FMS delivery delays may result in cancellations, potentially affecting U.S. and partner interoperability and integration. Congress is considering legislation that would require the integration of FMS demand into industrial base planning (H.R. 8800, §1817). Congress may also consider how the executive branch develops and updates prioritization criteria for FMS and whether coproduction efforts could augment U.S. capacity.

Tactical and Strategic Vulnerabilities. Congress may consider the potential vulnerabilities associated with shortages of certain munitions and reported damage to associated defense systems. In the near term, potential vulnerabilities may include a narrowing of options for sustaining operations in Iran and sustaining U.S. allies. In the medium term, Congress may assess how depleted stockpiles may affect the U.S. ability to "erect a strong denial defense along the First Island Chain" in the Indo-Pacific, as described in the 2026 National Defense Strategy.

Author Information

Hannah D. Dennis
Analyst in U.S. Defense Policy

Daniel M. Gettinger
Analyst in U.S. Defense Policy

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